

‘Lala, I get sudden attacks of dizziness these days, and my cough too has not fully subsided even after medicines,’ my father told me one morning as I was heading for work. Bauji was pushing seventy, but in very good health for somebody his age. The same evening I accompanied him to our family doctor, who recommended a CT scan and referred us to a pulmonologist.

A few days later, I was sitting across the doctor as he studied the test reports. I could sense he had some unpleasant news to give and that he was struggling to find the right words and break it to me as gently as he could.

‘I am afraid I have some bad news for you, Mr Lalchand . . . Your father doesn’t have much time left,’ he said. ‘It is cancer of the lung . . . now in its final stage.’ The words hit me like a punch in the chest; I was overcome by a sudden wave of breathlessness and was too stunned to respond.

‘This . . . this cannot be . . . my father is very healthy, and except for the recent cough and the occasional dizziness, he never had much to complain about,’ I told the doctor when I finally gathered my wits.

‘Often, the disease spreads across the body without a warning and is discovered very late. I am sorry, but there is little that can be done at this stage,’ the doctor said, trying to sound as sympathetic as he could.

‘How much time does he have?’ I asked.

‘At best, two months,’ the doctor replied.

‘Is there anything at all that can be done?’ I asked.

‘If your question is whether spending money on treatment will help, I would say that you could lessen the pain a bit, but not necessarily prolong his life,’ the doctor said.

‘If I can’t save his life, I shall do everything within my power to ensure that he suffers as little as possible in his final days,’ I said.

‘But let me warn you that the treatment will be expensive, and will not make much difference to the final outcome,’ the doctor said.

He told me that the drugs and chemotherapy could set me back by nearly Rs 10 lakh. I had reached a stage where Rs 10 lakh was affordable, but the incident also showed up to me the limitations of money. Yet I was thankful to God for helping me get to a position that allowed me to make things easier for my father in his final days.

The difficult part now was to get my father to agree to chemotherapy. I had told him he was absolutely fine. Naturally, he would ask why he had to undergo treatment if there was nothing wrong with him. Bina and I finally managed to convince him that he had to take the medicines and undergo